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Slideshow: Acres of potential in Beaver County



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For this week's edition of the [Pittsburgh Business Times](#), I spoke with representatives of the Ohio River Area-wide Brownfields Planning Project to discuss their proposals to reimagine the brownfields that line Beaver County's river banks.

The Borough of Monaca received a \$150,000 grant from the EPA in 2011 as part of a pilot program promoting an area-wide planning approach to community brownfield challenges. Partnering with the City of Aliquippa, the Borough of Coraopolis, the Borough of Midland and the Ohio River Trail Council, the communities joined together to undertake a grassroots effort to rethink the future of these areas as a way to overcome the loss of a significant portion of the county's manufacturing and industrial base.

What came of this collaboration is a community-led effort to promote the clean-up and redevelopment of 40 miles of former industrial lands along the Ohio River. Connecting Beaver County with Allegheny County, the idea is to promote smart-growth development practices.

[The U.S. Environmental Protection Agency](#) defines a brownfield as real property, the expansion, redevelopment, or reuse of which may be complicated by the presence, or potential presence, of a hazardous substance, pollutant, or contaminant.

[Mario Leone](#) Jr., borough manager for Monaca, said redevelopment of these brownfield sites is an important step to building up the county's economy.

"We want to see redevelopment; it will bring added tax revenue and the economic stimulus the area needs," he said.

The communities worked with Somerset-based [Stromberg/Garrigan & Associates Inc.](#), a planning and design firm that focuses on the revitalization and redevelopment of communities, to craft a reuse plan.

The slideshow on the right shows some of the reuse proposals that resulted from the project. The complete master plan is [available on the Ohio River Brownfields Project's website](#).

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